vulnerable candidate. Dr Sarabhai’s questions did not probe my existing knowledge or skil s; rather they were an exploration of the possibilities I was fil ed with. He was looking at me as if in reference to a larger whole. The entire encounter seemed to me a total moment of truth, in which my dream was enveloped by the larger dream of a bigger person.

I was advised to stay back for a couple of days.

However, the next evening I was told about my selection. I was to be absorbed as a rocket engineer at INCOSPAR.

This was a breakthrough a young man like myself dreamed of.

My work at INCOSPAR commenced with a familiarization course at the TIFR Computer Centre. The atmosphere here was remarkably different from that at DTD&P (AIR). Labels mattered very little. There was no need for anyone to justify his position or to be at the receiving end of the others’ hostility.

Some time in the latter half of 1962, INCOSPAR took the decision to set up the Equatorial Rocket Launching Station at Thumba, a sleepy fishing vil age near Trivandrum (now Thiruvananthapuram) in Kerala. Dr Chitnis of the